GLASSHOUSE

THE SCRIMMAGE LINE

After the bruising defeats in Haryana and Maharashtra, the INDIA bloc is back to its favourite pastime—bickering over who will lead the Opposition alliance. The Congress party, buoyed by its Lok Sabha gains, had all but anointed **Rahul Gandhi** captain, but after the poll debacles, the crown lies uneasy. Enter **Mamata Banerjee**, Bengal CM and TMC supremo, who has thrown her hat into the ring with endorsements from old Maratha warhorse Sharad Pawar and RJD patriarch Laloo Prasad Yadav. Meanwhile, the SP's Ram Gopal Yadav has decided that octogenarian Congress president **Mallikarjun Kharge** should lead the charge, a sentiment at odds with UP Congress chief Ajay Rai's claim that Rahul is the bloc's natural leader. All the scramble to displace her son no doubt left Congress grande dame Sonia Gandhi in no mood to celebrate her birthday on December 9.



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE



ANI

Polished Protest

Prime Minister **Narendra Modi's** gift of a lab-grown diamond (LGD) to First Lady Jill Biden during his visit to the US in June 2023 had left the old-school diamond barons in Surat clutching their natural stones in despair. Enter **Govindbhai Dholakia**, Surat's diamond czar and BJP Rajya Sabha MP, who appears to have taken it upon himself to remind the PM of the enduring sparkle of the real deal. In a stroke of patriotic bling, Dholakia presented Modi with a 2.1 carat natural diamond, meticulously shaped like the map of India. Christened 'Navbharat Ratna', this gem was apparently perfected after artisans toiled for over 60 hours. Valued at around Rs 4 lakh, the diamond was both a shiny reminder of Surat's craftsmanship and, perhaps, a subtle nudge to keep the faux sparklers where they belong—in the science lab.

Naidu's New Nest

Andhra Pradesh chief minister N. Chandrababu Naidu is finally putting down roots in new capital Amaravati, on a 25-acre plot in Velagapudi. And what a home it will be: a vastu-compliant marvel with manicured lawns, water bodies and quarters for his vast entourage. Set to be ready in a couple of years, this one will likely outpace Amaravati itself in completion. Incidentally, this will be Naidu's fourth abode, after his homes in Hyderabad, in native Naravaripalle and constituency HQ, Kuppam. For a four-term CM, though, who's counting?



Is this Seat Taken?

The Bihar assembly poll may still be a faint drumroll in the distance, but **Tej Pratap Yadav**, elder son of Lalu Prasad and Hasanpur's wildcard MLA, has already begun stirring the pot. Known for his theatrics, Tej dropped a bombshell on December 8: he might return to former stomping ground, Mahua, but only, and only, if the people want it. The announcement has already left at least one Mahua resident in tears—MLA Mukesh Kumar Roshan (also from the RJD), who seemed visibly rattled after hearing the news.



STAY INVESTED

Rajasthan's much-touted investor summits have long been about event management and less about investment. A minuscule fraction of the headline-grabbing MoUs see the light of day while some use the agreements to grab land at cheap rates. However, during 'Rising Rajasthan', a three-day extravaganza in December, CM **Bhajan Lal Sharma** donned the mantle of a no-nonsense enforcer, declaring that investors—who had signed MoUs worth a staggering Rs 30 lakh crore—would be blocked from future summits if they fail to deliver. The CM's censure seems well-timed, especially with social media abuzz about a Rs 20,000 crore green energy deal signed by a small-time businessman whose net worth couldn't buy even a fraction of the turbines required.



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

Kaushik Deka with Jumana Shah, Rohit Parihar, Amarnath K. Menon and Amitabh Srivastava